

POLICY RESEARCH PAPER

Strengthening Women's Leadership in Rural India

A Policy Framework for Inclusive Governance and Sustainable Development

Prepared for

Youth Vision India (YVI)

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Executive Summary

Women's leadership is a cornerstone of inclusive governance and sustainable development. According to the Ministry of Panchayati Raj (2026) and UN Women (2024), women constitute nearly half of India's population, yet their leadership in rural governance, entrepreneurship, and community decision-making remains below potential, constrained by unequal access to education, finance, digital technology, and institutional support.

This paper examines rural women's leadership in India, reviews international best practice, and proposes an original **LEAD Framework** — Leadership Development, Education & Economic Inclusion, Access to Digital & Institutional Support, and Decision-Making & Democratic Participation — as an integrated policy model.

Key recommendations include Rural Women Leadership Academies, expanded digital governance training, stronger Gram Sabha participation, district-level mentorship, and improved access to credit and entrepreneurship. The paper also outlines a Youth Vision India (YVI) Action Plan to translate these recommendations into practice, supporting SDG 5, 8, 10, and 16.

1. Introduction

According to UN Women (2024), global evidence shows that when women participate actively in decision-making, institutions become more transparent and development outcomes improve. In rural India, where governance is closely tied to agriculture, livelihoods, and local resource management, women's leadership can transform not just individual lives but entire communities.

According to the Ministry of Panchayati Raj (2026), the 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act (1992) reserved seats for women in Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs) — one of the world's largest experiments in grassroots democratic participation, with a growing number of states — an estimated 19 to 21 states and Union Territories as of 2026, depending on reporting period — later raising reservation from 33% to 50%. Complementary initiatives — the National Rural Livelihoods Mission (NRLM), Self-Help Groups (SHGs), Beti Bachao Beti Padhao, Digital India, and Skill India — have expanded women's economic and digital participation.

Yet greater participation has not always meant greater influence. Unequal access to education, finance, technology, and mobility, combined with entrenched social norms and unpaid care responsibilities, means representation frequently remains symbolic rather than transformative. Strengthening women's leadership in rural India should therefore be treated as a strategic policy priority — not solely a gender-equality initiative — essential to accelerating the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and strengthening democratic institutions.

2. Methodology

This paper follows a desk-based policy research design, synthesising secondary data from government sources (Ministry of Panchayati Raj, Ministry of Rural Development, NABARD, RBI), institutional and academic research (WELL Labs, ISPP, IMPRI), international agency publications (UN Women, World Economic Forum, World Bank, UNDP), and verified news reporting (Press Information Bureau, IndiaSpend, Free Press Journal) published through July 2026.

Country case studies — Rwanda, Bangladesh, and Sweden — were selected purposively to represent three distinct leadership-building approaches (political-institutional, economic-community-based, and whole-of-government), enabling comparative analysis of mechanisms transferable to India's rural governance context. The Haryana case study was selected because the state has fully implemented 50% reservation yet shows a persistent representation-to-influence gap, directly illustrating this paper's central argument.

The LEAD Framework was derived through a gap-analysis approach: each existing scheme reviewed in Sections 4 and 5 was mapped against four functional dimensions — leadership capacity, economic inclusion, digital/institutional access, and democratic participation — to identify where coverage was

partial or fragmented. LEAD's four pillars correspond directly to the dimensions found to be inconsistently addressed by current policy.

Limitations: this paper synthesises literature and secondary data; it does not include original fieldwork, household surveys, or key-informant interviews. Cited statistics reflect the most recent publicly available figures as of July 2026 and should be re-verified against official releases before policy submission. Budget estimates in Table 4 are indicative and would require a formal Detailed Project Report (DPR) before costing approval.

3. Problem Statement

Despite constitutional safeguards, women in rural India remain underrepresented in positions of meaningful leadership. The central challenge is the persistent gap between formal representation and substantive leadership. According to WELL Labs (2026), elected women representatives frequently experience proxy decision-making, where male family members influence or exercise authority on their behalf, reducing autonomy and weakening democratic decentralisation.

Educational and digital divides compound the problem. According to NABARD (2024), limited land ownership, restricted institutional credit, and unpaid domestic work reduce women's economic independence, and fragmented mentoring systems leave newly elected women without the confidence, resources, or institutional support to lead effectively. Emerging pressures such as climate change, migration, and food insecurity demand a new generation of leaders equipped for increasingly complex local governance.

The central policy problem addressed by this paper is:

How can India move beyond symbolic representation to build a sustainable, evidence-based ecosystem that enables rural women to become effective leaders and agents of community transformation?

Table 1: Key Challenges Faced by Rural Women Leaders

Challenge	Description	Illustrative Impact
Proxy Decision-Making	Elected women representatives are often influenced or overridden by male family members in Panchayat affairs.	Reduced autonomy and weakened democratic decentralisation (WELL Labs, 2026).
Educational & Digital Divide	Gaps in higher education, leadership training and digital literacy limit confident participation in governance.	Difficulty engaging with e-governance platforms and policy documentation.
Economic Dependence	Limited land ownership, restricted credit access and unpaid care work reduce financial independence.	Constrained ability to contest elections or start enterprises (NABARD, 2024).

Challenge	Description	Illustrative Impact
Institutional Fragmentation	Mentoring and capacity-building mechanisms vary widely across states and districts.	Newly elected women lack consistent technical and governance training.
Socio-Cultural Barriers	Patriarchal norms, gender stereotypes and mobility restrictions persist in rural communities.	Representation remains largely symbolic rather than transformative.
Emerging Governance Challenges	Climate change, migration and food insecurity require new-generation leadership skills.	Existing frameworks rarely integrate gender-responsive rural planning.

Table 1. Summary of structural challenges affecting rural women's leadership in India.

4. Evidence & India's Current Position

Cross-country research consistently links women's leadership to stronger governance, accountability, and service delivery. According to UN Women (2024) and the World Economic Forum (2025), women remain underrepresented in political and administrative leadership worldwide, with progress in political empowerment lagging behind education and health — representation alone does not guarantee effective leadership.

India illustrates both the promise and the limits of this progress. According to the Ministry of Panchayati Raj (2026), PRI reservations have enabled more than 1.4 million women to serve as elected representatives, now constituting close to 49.7% of all Panchayat members nationally. According to the Ministry of Rural Development (2024), DAY-NRLM's Self-Help Group networks have strengthened financial inclusion and community leadership, with many SHG members later assuming Panchayat roles. Government schemes — Jan Dhan Yojana, Stand-Up India, Mudra Yojana — have further widened access to banking and enterprise finance.

The Ministry of Panchayati Raj has also moved from representation to capacity building. As reported by the Press Information Bureau (2025), approximately 2.86 million elected women representatives were trained under the Rashtriya Gram Swaraj Abhiyan (RGSA) between 2022 and December 2025, and the Sashakt Panchayat-Netri Abhiyan, launched in 2025, specifically targets the leadership acumen and independent decision-making capacity of women representatives — a direct institutional precedent for the Leadership Development pillar proposed in Section 6.

Case Study: Haryana

Haryana illustrates both the potential and the limits of representation-led reform. Through the Haryana Panchayati Raj (Second Amendment) Act, 2020, the state extended the constitutional one-third mandate to 50% reservation for women in Panchayati Raj Institutions (*Ministry of Panchayati Raj, 2020*). According to a 2025 ground assessment, women now hold approximately 48% of Sarpanch posts in the state — around 443 of 925 seats (*ISPP, 2025*) — despite Haryana's historically skewed sex ratio and lower rural female literacy. Case studies documented by the National Institute of Rural Development and Panchayati

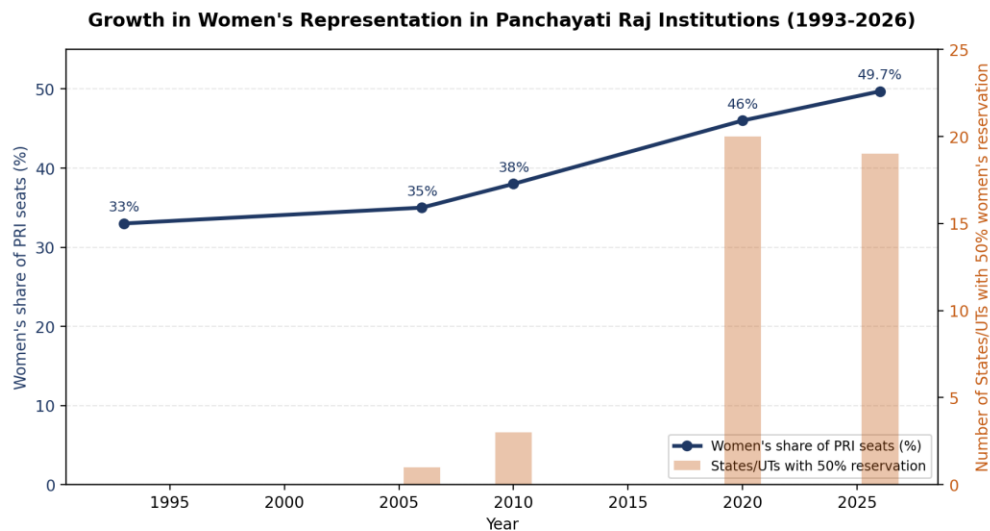
Raj (NIRDPR) show Haryana's women Sarpanches leading sanitation campaigns, improving school enrolment, and advancing women-centric welfare schemes, while parallel Self-Help Group and Lakhpati Didi networks under DAY-NRLM have expanded rural women's access to credit and enterprise income in the state.

This experience directly supports the LEAD Framework's premise: near-parity numerical representation (Haryana sits just under its 50% target) must be paired with training, financial autonomy, and institutional enforcement — the very gaps that persist even where reservation targets are largely met.

"I realised my experience is my strength. I understand my village," — Chandrakala Chattarsingh, 58, Sarpanch of Ghusgaon Panchayat, Madhya Pradesh, describing how a 12-day leadership training changed her approach after years of proxy participation through her son (Free Press Journal, 2026)

Nonetheless, implementation gaps persist: limited institutional capacity, inadequate leadership training, weak mentoring, and reliance on family members for administrative decisions reduce women's effective autonomy. States with stronger SHG movements and higher female literacy generally show better leadership outcomes, revealing sharp regional disparities. Research also shows women-led local governments prioritise drinking water, sanitation, health, and nutrition — outcomes that strengthen community resilience to climate and economic shocks. India's current position is therefore a transition phase: from ensuring representation towards enabling women to become influential, autonomous decision-makers.

Graph: Women's Representation in Panchayati Raj Institutions



Source: Ministry of Panchayati Raj (2026); IndiaSpend (2026); KPIAS Academy (2026); Bharat Docs (2026)

Figure 1. Growth in women's representation and states adopting 50% reservation in PRIs, 1993-2026 (Ministry of Panchayati Raj, 2026; IndiaSpend, 2026).

5. International Case Studies

Meaningful participation of women in decision-making requires more than legal representation — it requires sustained investment in education, institutional capacity, and leadership development. India can draw lessons from three contrasting international experiences.

4.1 Rwanda — Institutionalising Political Leadership

Rwanda has one of the highest levels of women's political representation in the world, with women holding a majority of parliamentary seats and playing a significant role in healthcare, education, and post-conflict reconstruction. **Key lesson:** having achieved strong PRI representation, India's next priority should be structured leadership training and mentorship rather than further electoral expansion.

4.2 Bangladesh — Community-Based Economic Leadership

Through microfinance institutions and women's cooperatives, millions of rural Bangladeshi women have gained financial access, entrepreneurship opportunities, and local decision-making influence. **Key lesson:** India's SHGs should evolve beyond financial inclusion into hubs for governance training and digital capacity building.

4.3 Sweden — Gender Mainstreaming in Public Policy

Sweden systematically evaluates the gender impact of every policy before implementation, embedding accountability across education, employment, and healthcare. **Key lesson:** every major Indian rural development programme should carry measurable indicators for women's participation and leadership outcomes.

Table 2: India vs Rwanda vs Bangladesh vs Sweden — Comparative Overview

Dimension	India	Rwanda	Bangladesh	Sweden
Primary Approach	Constitutional reservation in local bodies (33-50%)	Constitutional gender quotas in national parliament	Community-based microfinance & cooperatives	Whole-of-government gender mainstreaming
Representation Level	~49.7% of PRI seats; ~1.4 million elected women (Ministry of Panchayati Raj, 2026)	Majority of seats in national parliament	High participation in SHGs and cooperatives, not electoral quotas	Near-parity across public institutions
Economic Empowerment	SHGs, Lakhpati Didi, Mudra & Stand-Up India loans	Linked to post-conflict reconstruction programmes	Microfinance-led entrepreneurship at scale	Embedded in labour-market and welfare policy
Leadership Capacity Building	Fragmented; varies by state and scheme	Structured national leadership training	Integrated with livelihood programmes	Systematic, policy-embedded training

Dimension	India	Rwanda	Bangladesh	Sweden
Key Strength	Scale of grassroots representation	Sustained institutional commitment	Economic-leadership integration	Policy-wide accountability mechanisms

Table 2. Comparative approaches to women's leadership across four countries.

Despite differing political systems, all three countries share strong institutional commitment, continuous leadership capacity building, economic empowerment linked with governance, and gender-responsive policies backed by measurable outcomes — confirming that sustainable women's leadership requires a comprehensive ecosystem rather than isolated interventions.

6. Policy Recommendations: The LEAD Framework

To address the challenges identified above, this paper proposes an original policy model: the LEAD Framework.

LEAD = Leadership Development • Education & Economic Inclusion • Access to Digital & Institutional Support • Decision-Making & Democratic Participation

Unlike conventional approaches focused on numerical participation, LEAD aims to build capable, confident, and influential women leaders who actively shape governance and rural development.

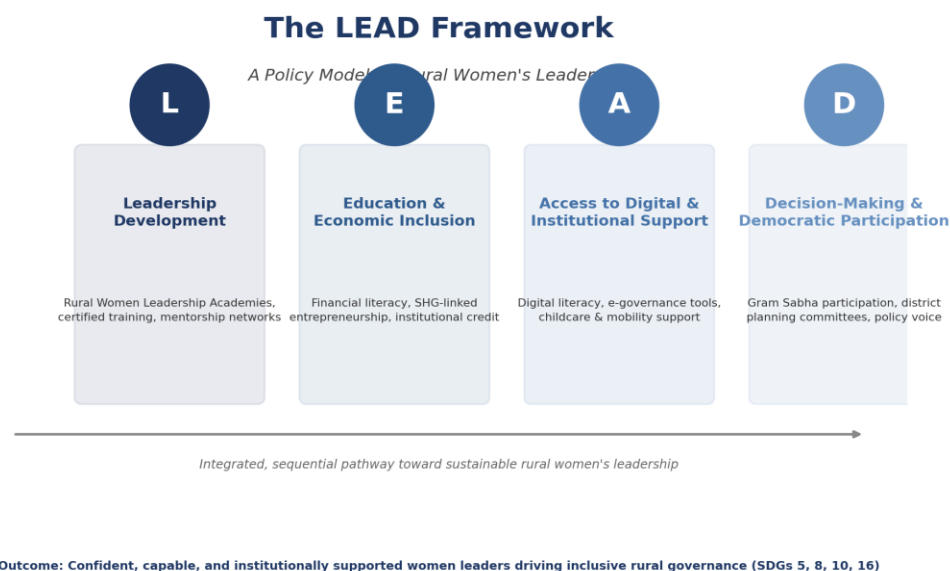


Figure 2. The LEAD Framework — an integrated policy model for rural women's leadership.

L — Leadership Development

- Establish Rural Women Leadership Academies at the district level.
- Certified leadership training with universities; mentorship networks linking experienced and newly elected women leaders.

E — Education & Economic Inclusion

- Expand entrepreneurship support and institutional credit access through SHGs.
- Promote digital financial literacy and women-led rural enterprises linked to local markets.

A — Access to Digital & Institutional Support

- Expand digital literacy and ensure equal access to government schemes.
- Improve childcare support, and promote inclusion of women with disabilities and minority communities.

D — Decision-Making & Democratic Participation

- Strengthen participation in Gram Sabha meetings and district planning committees.
- Encourage governance fellowships for young rural women and introduce annual leadership performance awards.

Why LEAD Is Different from Existing Leadership Models

Several established models already address pieces of this problem, but each covers only one dimension. Panchayati Raj reservation policies and Haryana's 2020 amendment secure numerical representation but stop there, without mandating training or economic follow-through. The Sashakt Panchayat-Netri Abhiyan and RGSA training programmes build leadership skills but operate independently of credit access or digital infrastructure. Sehgal Foundation's Women's Leadership School model integrates confidence-building with local governance participation, but is implemented village-by-village rather than as a scalable state or national policy architecture. Fellowship-style programmes such as the India RISE Fellowship build STEMM research capacity for individual women scientists, not grassroots governance capacity for elected representatives.

LEAD's originality lies not in any single pillar — each individually has precedent — but in **sequencing and integration**: it links leadership training, economic inclusion, digital/institutional access, and democratic participation into one district-implementable pathway, with measurable phase-wise milestones (see Table 3) rather than parallel, disconnected schemes. This distinguishes it from Rwanda's parliament-focused model, Sweden's whole-of-government approach, and Bangladesh's economic-first model — each strong in one dimension, none combined with India's specific rural-governance architecture.

Implementation Roadmap

Phase	Timeline	Action	Nodal Authority
Phase I	2026-27	Establish Rural Women Leadership Academies in pilot districts; launch mentorship pairing under the Leadership Development pillar.	Ministry of Panchayati Raj + State Rural Development Depts.
Phase II	2028-30	Scale digital literacy and e-governance training (Access pillar); integrate SHG credit and entrepreneurship linkages (Education & Economic Inclusion pillar).	Ministry of Rural Development (DAY-NRLM) + MeitY (Digital India)
Phase III	2030-35	National scale-up across all states/UTs; institutionalise Gram Sabha and district-planning participation (Decision-Making pillar); independent monitoring.	NITI Aayog (oversight) + State Panchayati Raj Depts.

Table 3. Phase-wise implementation roadmap for the LEAD Framework, with nodal implementing authority.

Indicative Budget Estimate

The following estimates are illustrative, benchmarked against the scale of the existing Rashtriya Gram Swaraj Abhiyan (RGSA), which was approved at a total outlay of ₹5,911 crore (Central share ₹3,700 crore; State share ₹2,211 crore) for 2022-23 to 2025-26. Actual costing would require a detailed DPR (Detailed Project Report) at the design stage.

Phase	Indicative Cost	Funding Source	Benchmark
Phase I (2026-27)	₹450-600 crore	Gender Budget allocation + State matching share (60:40, as per RGSA norm)	Comparable to one year's share of RGSA's ₹5,911 crore (2022-26) outlay
Phase II (2028-30)	₹1,200-1,500 crore	Central Sector convergence: DAY-NRLM + Digital India Mission funds	Scaled to cover digital + SHG components across ~120 Aspirational Districts
Phase III (2030-35)	₹2,500-3,000 crore	Union Budget Gender Budget line item + 15th/16th Finance Commission devolution	National scale-up, consistent with RGSA's full-scheme scale (₹5,911 crore/4 years)

Table 4. Indicative phase-wise budget estimate, benchmarked against RGSA (Ministry of Panchayati Raj, 2022).

Risk & Mitigation

Risk	Impact	Mitigation Strategy
Political/patriarchal resistance to women's independent decision-making	High	Engage male family members and village elders directly in orientation sessions; publicise success stories (e.g., Haryana, Madhya Pradesh) to shift social norms.

Risk	Impact	Mitigation Strategy
Centre-State coordination delays in fund release	Medium	Use existing RGSA/DAY-NRLM fund-flow mechanisms rather than creating new channels; joint monitoring via NITI Aayog.
Elite capture / benefits limited to already-empowered women	Medium	Target selection criteria weighted towards SC/ST, first-time representatives, and low-literacy districts.
Trainer and infrastructure capacity gaps in remote districts	Medium	Phased rollout starting with Aspirational Districts; leverage existing RGSA-trained master trainers.
Attrition — women not contesting a second term	High	Mentorship continuity beyond one term; recognition and awards (D pillar) to sustain motivation.

Table 5. Key implementation risks and corresponding mitigation strategies.

Monitoring & Evaluation Framework

Indicator	Baseline (2026)	2030 Target	2035 Target
Women PRI representatives trained under LEAD Leadership Academies	0	500,000	1.4 million (saturation)
Districts with operational Rural Women Leadership Academies	0	120 (Aspirational Districts)	All districts (~750)
Women PRI reps with independent digital/e-governance access	~46% (RGSA, 2025)	65%	85%
Women reservation compliance (states/UTs at 50%)	19-21 states	25 states/UTs	All states/UTs
Second-term contestation rate among trained women reps	Not tracked nationally	+15 percentage points over baseline cohort	+30 percentage points over baseline cohort

Table 6. Indicator-based monitoring and evaluation framework with baseline and phase-wise targets.

Expected Policy Outcomes

- Stronger, more accountable rural governance and higher women's participation in decision-making.
- Greater financial independence and community resilience against climate and economic shocks.

- Faster progress towards SDGs 5, 8, 10, and 16, and a new generation of rural women policy leaders.

7. Youth Vision India (YVI) Action Plan

YVI can play a catalytic role in strengthening women's leadership at the grassroots level through research, capacity building, policy advocacy, and community engagement. Proposed initiatives include:

- **Rural Women Leadership Fellowship:** an annual programme mentoring young rural women through workshops, field research, and public speaking.
- **District Policy Research Labs:** university partnerships analysing local governance challenges and developing evidence-based recommendations.
- **Digital Leadership Training:** certified programmes on digital literacy, e-governance, AI for public administration, and financial inclusion.
- **National Rural Women Leadership Summit:** an annual platform for policymakers, elected representatives, SHGs, and researchers to exchange knowledge.
- **Community Leadership Innovation Awards:** recognising outstanding women leaders in governance, health, and rural entrepreneurship.
- **Policy Monitoring & Impact Assessment:** periodic evaluation of leadership initiatives through measurable participation and institutional-performance indicators.

Conclusion

Women's leadership is a strategic investment in inclusive governance and sustainable national development, not merely a matter of gender equality. India's constitutional reforms and rural development programmes have created an enabling environment, but meaningful leadership demands continuous investment in education, digital inclusion, institutional support, and mentorship.

The LEAD Framework offers an integrated policy model — combining leadership development, economic inclusion, digital and institutional access, and democratic participation — while the proposed YVI Action Plan shows how youth-led research can complement government efforts. Strengthening rural women's leadership will accelerate progress towards SDGs 5, 8, 10, and 16 and help India recognise women as equal partners in governance, policy innovation, and sustainable development.

India cannot achieve Viksit Bharat 2047 without transforming rural women from beneficiaries into policy leaders.

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Note: All statistics should be verified against the latest official releases of the cited sources prior to final submission.